

UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper 1 Simulation

QUESTION PAPER | Time: 3 Hours | Maximum Marks: 250

INSTRUCTIONS

1. The paper has two sections, A and B, and eight questions.
2. Question 1 and Question 5 are compulsory.
3. Answer three other questions, choosing at least one from each section.
4. Answer five questions in all. The marks carried by each subpart are indicated.

SECTION A - Socio-Political Philosophy

Q1 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) Explain the distinction between a claim-right and a liberty, and show why the distinction matters for the relation between the individual and the state. [10 marks]
- (b) "Corrupt practices reveal an inherent tension between particularistic and universalistic normative standards." Do you agree with this statement? Give reasons and justification for your answer. [10 marks]
- (c) "Merit is a moral entitlement." Examine this claim. [10 marks]
- (d) Compare socialism and communism as two distinct political ideologies. [10 marks]
- (e) Do you agree that the rights concerning land and property have empowered women? Discuss. [10 marks]

Q2

- (a) "Human rights and human dignity would no longer be the product of a particular culture, rather a common human aspiration for an ideal world." Discuss. [20 marks]
- (b) "Duties are of the nature of obligation while Rights are of the nature of entitlement. Therefore there is no necessary connection between the two." Do you agree with this statement? Give reasons and justification for your answer. [15 marks]
- (c) "Guilt is individual; responsibility admits of collective forms." Critically examine this claim in the context of mass violence. [15 marks]

Q3

- (a) "Punishment is a constrained practice, not a free exercise of state power." Discuss with reference to corruption, mass violence and capital punishment. [20 marks]
- (b) Compare Berlin and Green on the meaning of liberty, and assess whether their positions can be reconciled. [15 marks]
- (c) Are Marxian Socialism and individual freedom consistent? Discuss critically. [15 marks]

Q4

- (a) Discuss whether Amartya Sen's idea of justice is an improvement upon Rawls's theory of justice. [20 marks]
- (b) Discuss gender as a cultural category as opposed to sex as a biological category. [15 marks]
- (c) Distinguish civil disobedience from conscientious objection, resistance and revolution, and examine whether a constitutional democracy can consistently accommodate any of them. [15 marks]

SECTION B - Philosophy of Religion

Q5 (COMPULSORY)

- (a) Write an essay on Spinoza's notion of God and His attributes. [10 marks]

- (b) "Toleration granted by the strong to the weak is permission, not equality." Examine. (Answer in about 150 words.) [10 marks]
- (c) Explain why classical Mimamsa is often regarded as the sharpest counterexample to the claim that religion requires God. [10 marks]
- (d) Does the doctrine of divine simplicity strengthen or weaken the notion of a personal God? Give reasons for your answer. [10 marks]
- (e) Is there any compatibility between 'Freedom of Will' and 'Omnipotent God'? Discuss. [10 marks]

Q6

- (a) All evil is either sin or punishment for sin." - St. Augustine. Critically discuss. [20 marks]
- (b) Explain the main tenets of the Process Theodicy as an explanation of the problem of evil. [15 marks]
- (c) If God is the Absolute Creator, then the responsibility of the evil cannot belong to the human agent. Critically examine. [15 marks]

Q7

- (a) Examine whether the epistemology of deep disagreement strengthens or weakens the case for religious pluralism. (Answer in about 350 words.) [20 marks]
- (b) Does the concept of God entail the existence of God? Examine from the perspective of ontological argument. [15 marks]
- (c) Does religious pluralism require abandoning the claim that any religion possesses absolute truth? Critically discuss. [15 marks]

Q8

- (a) Present a critical exposition of different arguments offered by St. Thomas Aquinas to prove the existence of God also known as 'Five Ways'. Which one of them do you find philosophically most interesting? Give reasons in support of your answer. [20 marks]
- (b) Is morality autonomous from religion even when moral life is interpreted as obedience to God? Examine. [15 marks]
- (c) Explain the relation between the God and the Self according to Ramanujacarya. [15 marks]

END OF PAPER